behavior and on the behavior of new nuclear powers generally. In two contrasting sections, one by Ganguly and one by Kapur, we develop our arguments. In chapter 4, we assess nuclear weapons' past impact on the South Asian security environment. The chapter examines the three major confrontations of the nuclear era—the 1990 standoff, the Kargil war, and the 2001–2002 standoff—according to the competing frameworks developed in chapter 3. Ganguly argues that nuclear weapons ensured that these crises did not escalate to the level of nuclear or full-scale conventional conflict. Kapur maintains that nuclear weapons facilitated the crises' outbreak and had little to do with their resolution.

In chapter 5, we address the current strategic environment in South Asia. Ganguly argues that by making continued conflict prohibitively dangerous, nuclear weapons have helped to promote the recent thaw in Indo-Pakistani relations. Kapur maintains that improvements in the regional security environment are modest and result more from economic, diplomatic, and domestic political factors than from nuclear deterrence.

We also look to South Asia's future. Ganguly predicts that the same deterrent logic that underlies recent improvements in the regional security environment is likely to continue to stabilize South Asia in the years to come. Despite acute crises in the region none of them have spiraled out of control and there appears to be little reason based on the available evidence to believe that they are likely to do so. Kapur claims that Indo-Pakistani conflict during the 1998–2002 period, which nuclear weapons facilitated, has led the Indians to begin formulating a more aggressive conventional military doctrine. This could increase Indo-Pakistani security competition and result in rapid escalation in the event of an actual conflict.

Finally, in chapter 6, we depart from our debate-oriented framework and discuss three issues about which we agree. First, we contextualize our competing arguments, as well as the standard nuclear optimist and pessimist claims, as part of what we call outcome- and process-based approaches to nuclear proliferation. Second, we argue against the potential introduction of ballistic missile defense capabilities into South Asia. Although BMD is billed as a defensive measure, in our view it would probably encourage